coalesced in the early years of the decade in response to military interventions into the Tribal Areas. Al-Qaeda's growing presence in South Waziristan and escalating raids into Afghanistan led to US pressure on Pakistan to take action. The government initially tried to negotiate the handover of foreign fighters present in the Tribal Areas, but after attempts at diplomacy and bribery failed, Pakistan launched a series of incursions into South Waziristan. These efforts resulted in significant losses for the military and failed to halt cross-border activity or permanently dislodge al-Qaeda militants, many of whom relocated to North Waziristan where they were welcomed by the Haqqani Network.[64] It is named for its leader Jalaluddin Haqqani, a legendary commander during the anti-Soviet jihad in Afghanistan who was also a favorite of the US at the time. His network is closely aligned with the Taliban and is one of the main insurgent groups active in the Afghan insurgency against Coalition forces. Its leadership is close to both the ISI, which has supported its efforts across the Durand Line, as well as to al-Qaeda.

The first significant military incursion into South Waziristan began in March 2004 and was followed by a peace agreement with tribal militants in late April. More fighting ensued from June through January 2005, with yet another peace agreement signed in February. The accord was intended to spare the army further losses and to restore the status quo, whereby the tribes were held responsible for maintaining security in FATA. The militants with whom the state was dealing, however, had no intention of returning to the status quo and the state's willingness to cut deals only emboldened them to expand their writ. Meanwhile, al-Qaeda members and other foreign fighters migrated to North Waziristan, which became their main base for operations. Pro-Taliban militias were emerging in other tribal agencies, as well as in parts of the NWFP, during this time too. In January 2006, Hellfire missiles fired from an American CIA-operated drone obliterated three buildings, described as safe houses, in Damadola village in Bajaur. The strike was intended to kill Ayman al-Zawahiri, al-Qaeda's number 2, but he had left hours earlier. Instead, the strike claimed the lives of eighteen civilians, including five women and five children. This fueled anti-American sentiment across the country and especially in the Tribal Areas where approximately 8,000 Pashtun tribesmen protested, sparking an acceleration of violence.[65] Militants came out in the open in FATA that year, ambushing army convoys, attacking military and government